your neighbours might acknowledge your right to cultivate a field but not your right to sell it to foreigners.[14]

In a literate state, to own a field increasingly came to mean that it is written on some clay tablet, bamboo strip, piece of paper or silicon chip that you own that field. If your neighbours have been grazing their sheep for years on a piece of land, and none of them ever said that you own it, but you can somehow produce an official document that says it is yours, you have a good chance of enforcing your claim. Conversely, if all the neighbours agree that it is your field but you don't have any official document that proves it, tough luck. Ownership is still an intersubjective reality created by exchanging information, but the information now takes the form of a written document (or a computer file) rather than of people talking and gesturing to each other. This means that ownership can now be determined by a central authority that produces and holds the relevant documents. It also means that you can sell your field without asking your neighbours' permission, simply by transferring the crucial document to someone else.

The power of documents to create intersubjective realities was beautifully manifested in the Old Assyrian dialect, which treated documents as living things that could also be killed. Loan contracts were 'killed' (*duākum*) when the debt was repaid. This was done by destroying the tablet, adding some mark to it or breaking its seal. The loan contract didn't represent reality; it *was* the reality. If somebody repaid the loan but failed to 'kill the document', the debt was still owed. Conversely, if somebody didn't repay the loan but the document 'died' in some other way – perhaps the dog ate it – the debt was no more.[15] The same happens with money. If your dog eats a hundred-dollar bill, those hundred dollars cease to exist.

In Shulgi's Ur, in ancient Assyria and in numerous subsequent polities, social, economic and political relations relied on documents that create reality instead of merely representing it. When writing constitutions, peace treaties and commercial contracts, lawyers, politicians and businesspeople wrangle for weeks and even months over each word – because they know that these pieces of paper can wield enormous power.